

Zero Sum RPG Scenario: The Cobalt Pipeline

Real-World Inspiration

This scenario is heavily anonymized but conceptually derived from current worldwide events regarding: **Tech supply chains reliant on brutalized mine labor**. It integrates modern digital demagogue mechanics and corporate overreach.

1. The Hook

The players are contracted to infiltrate a highly secure Refinery in Eastern Europe. An influential **Viral Prankster** has weaponized their parasocial swarm of millions of followers to act as an unwitting shield for an illegal operation happening inside. The authorities will not intervene out of fear of a massive PR disaster and riots.

2. The Digital Demagogue

The primary antagonist isn't a heavily armed warlord, but an influencer who commands attention. They don't use guns; they use live-streams. If the players are detected, the influencer will immediately broadcast their faces, instantly raising the Social Heat to maximum and doxxing them globally.

3. The Complication

Violence is not an option here. *Alternatively, the players can leverage Deep Cover to bypass the guard entirely by passing a DC 2 Subterfuge check. The area is flooded with lethal PMC guards; stealth is mandatory.* If a single shot is fired, the Dead Man's Zone

rule applies, and the players will face an impossible extraction against overwhelming force.

4. Zero Sum Consistency Matrix (ZSCM)

To ensure the scenario maintains the brutal asymmetry of the *Zero Sum* system, the ZSCM values are pre-calculated:

- **Antagonist Power (E):** 7/10
- **Player Starting Resources (R):** 5/10
- **Initial Intel Asymmetry (I):** 6/10
- **Collateral Damage Risk (D):** 4/10
- **Total Stress Score:** 22/30 (Valid: Mechanically Solvable but Asymmetric)

5. Objectives & Extraction

1. **Infiltrate:** Bypass the physical security without alerting the follower swarm.
2. **Isolate:** Disconnect the influencer from the global network to stop the broadcast threat.
3. **Extract:** Secure the objective data and vanish before the algorithmic police response arrives.